SUMIT KUMAR



MOVING ON Siddiqui says 15,000 BSP workers have left

into a direct fight between the BJP and Akhilesh Yadav's party.

Much of the BSP's old guard, blooded in Kanshi Ram's early movement, has gravitated towards the SP. The latest to pitch tent here is Naseemuddin Siddiqui. A BSP founding member, once among its most influential leaders after Mayawati and Satish Mishra, he was expelled in 2017 and joined the Congress. Now he has finished the logical end of that journey, alongside former minister Anees Ahmad Khan, who came over on a direct flight from the BSP.

THE KANSHI RAM CLASS

In the past six years, around a dozen former Mayawati cabinet ministers have shifted to the SP. Other names too are politically weighty: Babu Kushwaha, Lalji Verma, Daddu Prasad, Ram Achal Rajbhar, Badshah Singh, Indrajit Saroj, Veer Singh, Akbar Hussain and Ram Prasad Chaudhary.

To fully gauge the blood loss, add Swami Prasad Maurya and Dara Singh Chauhan. Both made the same leap but later exited the SP: Maurya for his own political startup, Dara opting for the BJP. Over a dozen former BSP MLAs and MPs too have moved to the SP.

None of them are trivial figures. Kushwaha once had the medical and panchayati raj portfolios; Verma finance and planning. Plus, leaders do not move alone. They bring caste networks, booth-level cadre and personal vote banks built over decades—exactly what had once sustained the BSP's formidable ground game.

Siddiqui claims over 15,000 party workers have left the BSP to join him. "There are times when you have to take certain decisions. Our focus has to be on the state's larger interest, and strengthen the platform that moves in that direction," he tells INDIA TODAY.

Leaders in the SP say it's not opportunism for either side. They cite the PDA plank, shorthand for the party's 'OBC-Dalit-Muslim' umbrella, as the ideological glue binding these shifts. Akhilesh frames it as an appeal to unity beyond silos—language that feels familiar to many former BSP leaders. Early BSP politics dovetailed Dalit interests with Extremely Backward Classes and Muslims—a social coalition internal critics say the BSP has drifted away from. PDA, says Anees Ahmad, has effectively filled that vacuum.

It's a *sarv samaj* line, a contrast to deepening communal polarisation, with a visibilised Dalit outreach. In 2022, the SP formed the Baba Saheb Vahini, named after B.R. Ambedkar, and began marking Kanshi Ram's birth anniversary with greater prominence. The symbolism has material benefits. ■

Takeaways

- **About a dozen former Mayawati cabinet faces in SP now; Naseemuddin Siddiqui latest to shift**
- **Old-timers say BSP has drifted from its old politics, they find echoes of Kanshi in SP's PDA**

By **Jeemon Jacob**

GOD'S OWN COUNTRY MAY HAVE SERIOUS attention deficit right now, with missiles and kamikaze drones hitting what's often called "the 15th district of Kerala". But politics here is producing a heat map no less torrid than what's unfolding in the Gulf. Chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar is due for a weekend visit, and no party is immune to a touch of signal fluctuation as top leaders press in for their individual stakes in the upcoming assembly election—or miss out.

Start at the top. On February 27, the CPI(M) politburo in Delhi put its sign on strongman chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan "leading" the Left Democratic Front (LDF) campaign—inter alia, relaxing the party's 75-year age limit to enable the 80-year-old veteran to contest, a bar they have lifted a few times for internal party mechanisms too. Still, a slight gap showed.

POLL BUGLE: WHO'S IN, WHO'S OUT

PADMAJA VENUGOPAL, 66

Daughter of ex-CM and late Congress icon K. Karunakaran set for lotus rebirth





THOMAS ISAAC, 73

CPI(M)'s scholarly ex-FM conspicuous by his absence in list, though only 73

